

GTALES PARENT GUIDE 02 · WORRY & FEAR

Small Steps, Big Courage

A calm, science-based plan to help your child shrink worries, face fears in small steps, and feel brave again.

Small cloud = brave · Growing cloud = worried · Big cloud = stuck

The guide in 60 seconds

1. Fear is normal. Most children aged 4–12 have fears, and only about 1 in 10 has an anxiety problem.
2. The hidden cause: too much rescuing. Reassuring again and again, or letting a child skip every scary thing, keeps fear alive.
3. The fix is small brave steps, with you beside them: "I know it's hard, and I know you can do it."

First, take a breath

Fear is a normal, healthy feeling. Most young children are scared of something, like the dark, monsters, or saying goodbye. Being brave is not something a child has or does not have. It is a skill, and you can teach it at home.

PART 1

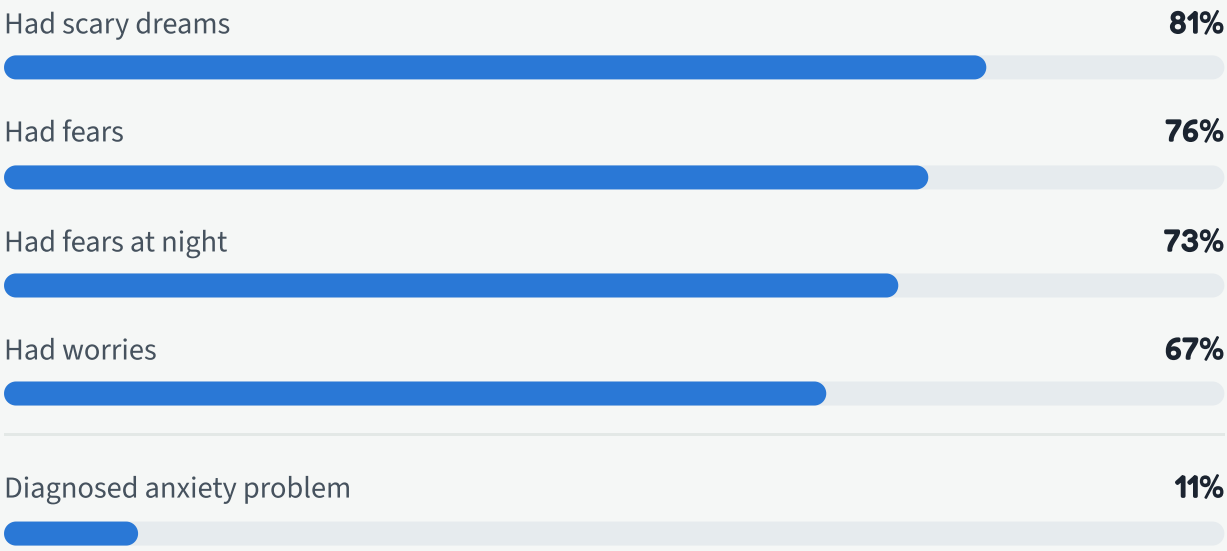
Understanding worry and fear

Fear is the body's alarm system. A small part of the brain, the amygdala, shouts "danger!" Then the heart beats fast, the tummy feels tight, and the child wants to run or hide. This alarm keeps us safe. But in young children it often rings for things that are not really dangerous.

At 4 to 6, children cannot always tell what is real and what is pretend. So monsters, the dark, and bad dreams feel very real. Around 7 and 8, fears move to real-world things, like getting hurt, bad news, or losing a family member. Most fears fade with time, especially when a child learns to face them in small steps.

Most children have fears. Few have an anxiety problem.

Fears, worries and scary dreams: 190 ordinary schoolchildren aged 4–12 (Netherlands). Night fears: 176 children aged 4–12. Anxiety problem: US children aged 3–17, diagnosed by a doctor, 2023–2024.



Source: Muris et al., 2000; Muris et al., 2001; CDC

What it looks like at each age

Age 4–5

WHAT IS COMMON

Fear of the dark, monsters, loud noises (thunder, fireworks), bad dreams, and being apart from you at bedtime or nursery.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Fear stops daily life: cannot sleep without you every night, screams at every goodbye for weeks, or often has tummy aches before going out.

Age 6–7

WHAT IS COMMON

Night fears and scary dreams are still common. New fears appear: getting hurt, "bad people", storms, being away from family, trying new things.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Asks the same "What if...?" question again and again, refuses school or parties, needs you to check or promise many times a day.

Age 8

WHAT IS COMMON

Worries about real things: school work, mistakes, friends, health of family members, scary news.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Worry takes a lot of time each day, body pains with no medical cause, avoids more and more places, or the fear is much bigger than other children's.

PART 2

Why it happens

THE SURPRISING PART

The loving things we do to calm a scared child, like reassuring, rescuing, and staying close, can keep the fear alive.

Scientists call this "accommodation": changing what the family does so the child does not feel fear. In one study, 97% of fathers of anxious children did it, and 70% gave reassurance, often every day. It brings calm today, but the child never learns "I can do this", so the fear stays. In a Yale trial with 124 anxious children, parents learned to slowly do less of this and to say "I know it's hard, and I know you can do it". This parent-only program worked as well as therapy given to the child.

Source: Alcan et al., 2022 · Lebowitz et al., 2020

Three common myths

MANY PARENTS THINK

"If I reassure her enough, the fear will go."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

Reassurance calms the moment but teaches nothing. In one study, 70% of fathers of anxious children reassured, often daily, and the fear stayed. Fewer promises, more small steps.

MANY PARENTS THINK

"Let him skip it. He'll grow out of it."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

Avoiding keeps fear alive. Facing it slowly works: after CBT, 49% of young people were free of their main anxiety problem, against 18% who waited.

MANY PARENTS THINK

"Only a therapist can fix this."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

Parents can. In a Yale trial of 124 anxious children, a program that trained only the parents worked as well as therapy for the child.

Source: Alcan et al., 2022 · James et al., 2020 · Lebowitz et al., 2020

What's underneath

Clinging and crying are the tip. Under the water, there are often hidden reasons.

WHAT YOU SEE

Clinging | Tears at goodbye | Won't sleep alone | Says "No!"

Avoiding the fear

Each time a child runs away from a fear, the brain learns "that was dangerous". The fear grows stronger. Facing it in small steps teaches the brain it is safe.

Source: KidsHealth, 2023

Too much rescuing

Parents often sleep beside the child, answer the same worry again and again, or skip the party. This feels kind, but it keeps fear going.

Source: Alcan et al., 2022

Copying our faces

Children watch our faces to decide if something is safe. In one study, toddlers avoided toys after their mother looked scared of them.

Source: Dubi et al., 2008

Scary information

Most children say their fears started from something they heard or saw. Scary shows, news, and grown-up talk can plant fears.

Source: Muris et al., 2001

No words yet

Young children feel fear in the body but cannot name it. Putting a feeling into words calms the brain's alarm.

Source: Lieberman et al., 2007

Big changes

A new school, a new baby, moving home, or family stress can make any child more clingy for a while. This is a normal reaction to change.

What makes it worse

Saying "There's nothing to be scared of" again and again, or letting your child skip everything that scares them, brings calm now but makes the fear last longer.

Source: Alcan et al., 2022

PART 3

In the moment: Notice, Name, Normalize, Nudge

Use these four steps when your child is scared. Stay calm and slow. Your calm is the strongest signal of safety.



1 **Notice**

Get down to your child's eye level. Look at the band together: is the cloud growing?

2 **Name**

Help your child say it out loud: "I'm scared." Do the Combo together: freeze and hug your tummy, three slow breaths, Power Word, then words.

3 **Normalize**

Show you understand: "It's OK to feel scared. Lots of kids feel this way." Do not argue with the feeling.

4 **Nudge**

Show you believe in them: "I know you can do this." Help them take one small brave step, not a giant one.

Naming a feeling calms the brain's alarm, and pairing understanding with confidence is the core of the proven SPACE program (Lieberman et al., 2007; Lebowitz et al., 2020).

What to say

SAY	INSTEAD OF
"You feel scared. That makes sense."	"Don't be silly, there's nothing there."
"I know it's hard, and I know you can do it."	"OK, you don't have to go."
"What could be one small brave step?"	"Just go, everyone else is fine."
"You already asked. What do you think the answer is?"	"For the tenth time, yes, I promise."
"I'll be back after snack time. I always come back."	Sneaking away so there are no tears.

After the worry: the 4 Rs

Rest
Give a hug and a quiet moment once the cloud is small again.

Recall
Talk about it later: "Your cloud was big, then it got smaller. What helped?"

Recognize
Praise the effort, not the result: "You were scared, and you still tried."

Rehearse
Plan the next small step together, so next time feels easier.

PART 4

Every day, when everyone is calm

Bravery grows in calm, ordinary moments, not only in scary ones. These small habits make a big difference over time.

Feelings talk every day

Name feelings at dinner or bedtime: "Today I felt worried when...". Share your own small worries and how you handled them. Children learn it is safe to say feelings out loud.

Calm, steady goodbyes

Keep goodbyes short, warm and the same every time. Say when you will return, and always come back. Do not sneak away.

A soothing bedtime routine

Same order every night: bath, story, song, light off. Predictable routines help the brain feel safe in the dark.

Less scary screen time

Choose shows for your child's age and watch together when you can. Keep news and adult worries out of little ears.

Show calm courage

Children copy our faces and voices. When you feel nervous, say it and face it calmly: "I'm a bit nervous, and I'll try anyway."

Reassure once, then trust

Answer a worry question one time. Then turn it back: "What do you think?" Repeated promises feed the worry loop.

This approach is proven

A large review of 39 studies with 2,697 young people found that 49% were free of their main anxiety problem after CBT, compared with 18% who waited. Programs led by parents also work: in a UK trial, 59% of children aged 5–12 were much better after brief, parent-guided CBT.

Source: James et al., 2020 · Creswell et al., 2017

PART 5

Seven activities that work

Each one takes a few minutes, uses things you already have, and practices one part of the Combo. Do them when everyone is calm.



Brave Ladder

Ages 4–8 · 10 min · Paper, crayons, stickers

1. Pick one fear, like sleeping with the light off.
2. Draw a ladder with 5 steps, easiest at the bottom (light on, door open) to hardest at the top (light off).
3. Climb one step at a time. Stay on a step for a few nights until the cloud is small.
4. Put a sticker on each step your child climbs.

Why it works: Facing fears slowly, from easy to hard, is the main tool of CBT, the most proven treatment for childhood anxiety (James et al., 2020).

Say It, Shrink It

Ages 4–8 · 5 min · A balloon or a drawing of a cloud

1. Ask your child to whisper a worry.
2. Draw a big cloud, then say the worry out loud together.
3. Draw a smaller cloud next to it.
4. Talk about how saying it made the worry feel smaller.

Why it works: Putting feelings into words calms the brain's alarm, just like in the story (Lieberman et al., 2007).

Combo Practice

Ages 4–8 · 5 min · None

1. Practice the Combo when your child is calm, not scared.
2. Freeze and hug your tummy.
3. Take three slow breaths, like blowing out birthday candles.
4. Say the Power Word, then: "I'm scared. I need..."

Why it works: Skills practiced in calm moments are easier to use in scary ones.

Flashlight Hunt

Ages 4–7 · 10 min · A flashlight or phone light, small toy

1. Hide a toy in a dim room while your child watches.
2. Turn the lights low, together at first.
3. Your child finds the toy with the flashlight.
4. Next time, make the room a little darker, or let them go alone.

Why it works: Playful, small steps into the dark teach the brain it is safe, like a mini brave ladder (KidsHealth, 2023).

Shadow Show

Ages 4–8 · 10 min · Lamp, wall, your hands

1. Make shadow animals on the wall with your hands.
2. Show that a tiny hand can make a giant shadow.
3. Ask: "Is the shadow scary, or just your hand?"
4. Let your child make a big kitten shadow, like Basbousa, and give it a kind voice.

Why it works: Like the Big Shadow in the story, it shows that many scary things look bigger in the dark than they really are.

Worry Time Box

Ages 6–8 · 10 min · A shoebox, paper, pencil

1. Your child draws or writes a worry and puts it in the box.
2. Choose one short "worry time" each day to open the box together.
3. Talk about each worry once, then close the lid.
4. Outside worry time, say: "Let's save it for the box."

Why it works: It helps you reassure once, not all day, which breaks the worry loop (Alcan et al., 2022).

Practice Goodbyes

Ages 4–6 · 5 min · A favourite toy, a kitchen timer

1. Play "goodbye" with a toy first: the toy leaves and always comes back.
2. Then you go to the next room for 1 minute, with the timer on.
3. Come back when the timer rings. Say "I came back!"
4. Slowly make the time longer.

Why it works: Short, planned separations help children learn that you always return (KidsHealth, 2023).

PART 6

Using your child's GTales story



Before

Read the title together and look at the cover. Ask: "What do you think a shadow could be?" Point to the band and show what small, growing and big clouds mean.

While reading

Pause when the cloud on the band grows. Ask: "How big is his cloud now? What could he do?" Do the Combo together when the boy does. At each challenge, let your child choose the small brave step.

After

Ask: "Was the Big Shadow really scary? Why was Basbousa hiding?" Talk about how saying a worry out loud made it smaller. Ask your child to name one small brave step they want to try this week.

Your 7-day plan

Day 1	Read the story together. Talk about the band and the three clouds.
Day 2	Practice the Combo when calm. Play Say It, Shrink It.
Day 3	Make a Shadow Show at bedtime.
Day 4	Draw a Brave Ladder for one real fear. Climb the first step.
Day 5	Play Flashlight Hunt or Practice Goodbyes.
Day 6	Re-read the story. Let your child guide the brave choices.
Day 7	Celebrate the steps climbed. Plan the next step on the ladder.

✂ CUT OUT AND KEEP ON THE FRIDGE

When the cloud gets big

1. Freeze and hug your tummy.
2. Three slow breaths.
3. Say your Power Word.
4. "I'm scared. I need…"

What grown-ups can say

- "You feel scared. That makes sense."
- "I know it's hard, and I know you can do it."
- "What's one small brave step?"

PART 7

When to get extra help

Most children get better with time, practice and calm support. Talk to a professional if you notice any of these:

- Fear stops your child from going to school, sleeping alone, or being apart from you for many weeks.
- Fears seem much bigger than other children's, or last long past the usual age.
- Frequent tummy aches, headaches, or a racing heart with no medical cause.
- Very strong tantrums or panic when facing a fear.
- Worry takes up a lot of the day, or your child asks for reassurance again and again.
- Your child avoids more and more places, people, or activities.
- Your family's daily life now changes a lot around the fear.

Talk to your child's doctor, a child psychologist, or a child psychiatrist. Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) is the proven first treatment, and parent-based programs like SPACE also work well.

Asking for help is a strong parenting move, not a failure.

Sources

1. Lebowitz ER, Marin C, Martino A, Shimshoni Y, Silverman WK. Parent-based treatment as efficacious as cognitive-behavioral therapy for childhood anxiety: a randomized noninferiority study of Supportive Parenting for Anxious Childhood Emotions. Journal of the American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry, 2020;59(3):362–372.
2. Alcan E, Anderson T, Lebowitz ER. Frequency and correlates of fathers' accommodation in pediatric anxiety disorders. Child Psychiatry & Human Development, 2022;53(5):1047–1061.
3. Muris P, Merckelbach H, Gadet B, Moulaert V. Fears, worries, and scary dreams in 4- to 12-year-old children: their content, developmental pattern, and origins. Journal of Clinical Child Psychology, 2000;29(1):43–52.
4. Muris P, Merckelbach H, Ollendick TH, King NJ, Bogie N. Children's nighttime fears: parent-child ratings of frequency, content, origins, coping behaviors and severity. Behaviour Research and Therapy, 2001;39(1):13–28.
5. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. Data and Statistics on Children's Mental Health (National Survey of Children's Health, 2023–2024).
6. Dubi K, Rapee RM, Emerton JL, Schniering CA. Maternal modeling and the acquisition of fear and avoidance in toddlers: influence of stimulus preparedness and child temperament. Journal of Abnormal Child Psychology, 2008;36(4):499–512.
7. Lieberman MD et al. Putting feelings into words: affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli. Psychological Science, 2007. (UCLA news release.)
8. James AC, Reardon T, Soler A, James G, Creswell C. Cognitive behavioural therapy for anxiety disorders in children and adolescents. Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews, 2020, Issue 11, CD013162.
9. Creswell C, Violato M, Fairbanks H, et al. Clinical outcomes and cost-effectiveness of brief guided parent-delivered cognitive behavioural therapy and solution-focused brief therapy for treatment of childhood anxiety disorders: a randomised controlled trial. The Lancet Psychiatry, 2017.
10. Nemours KidsHealth. Anxiety, Fears, and Phobias (for parents). Medically reviewed by Zachary Radcliff, PhD, September 2023.

Written from peer-reviewed research and public-health guidance. Expert review in progress. This guide is general information, not a substitute for advice from a qualified professional. © GTales